

production. "Would senators be wearing beards?" I was once asked urgently over the telephone. Instinctively I said, "No, by no means necessarily." And I started on a study of beard fashions through the Roman centuries—not very useful, but fascinating. (One item: young people would wear beards until white hairs became too numerous for the barber to be able to pluck them out. Vanity, I think, was also one reason for the usual Roman man's way of combing his hair forward: it concealed receding foreheads. Incidentally, in certain quarters in Rome it was fashionable again this year.)

Objects and properties help characterize backgrounds and people. At one point it was considered giving Cicero something that would correspond to a lorgnette. It would have been non-authentic, but the idea was discarded mainly because the particular object seemed actually superfluous. Shops, street vendors, Forum characters were based on as much literary and archaeological evidence as it was possible to assemble (Roman shop signs in bas-relief are often good pictures of the shops themselves.) Physical authenticity of individual characters was of course not attempted, though a collection of their available portraits was made, and their ages, qualities, ranks, backgrounds were defined. Here again, we have a case where the researcher is tempted to collect material of no direct usefulness but of obviously great fascination, as in the social studies of Rome by F. R. Cowell and L. R. Taylor.

Again, the artistic truth of characters within the drama is what counts, not their relation to history—especially as far as appearance is concerned. Caesar, God knows, was shorter than Mr. Calhern and it would be difficult to find somebody looking less like Cicero than the excellent Mr. Napier. I thought the matter of accents, by the way, turned out to add to characterization: the ultranoble Brutus and Cassius are English; the tougher Antony is American; Cicero, who was provincial middle class but very refined and like Brutus and Cassius much exposed to Greek culture, is English; while Casca is American.

Any result of research is subordinated to dramatic necessities, but sometimes there is a certain happy concomitance of the two. This occurred, for instance, with Brutus' camp at Philippi. The fact that Roman camps were, as is well known, quite elaborate and solid establishments coincided with the possibility of showing that some time had elapsed since the assassination and since Brutus and Cassius' departure from Rome.

A historical piece of information, even if correct and usable at the same time, may not be exploited fully. An example of this may be the question which was raised about some sort of ceremony that would precede the battle. Something like a prayer, a religious sanction, seemed dramatically appropriate; but of the ceremony (called *lustratio*) with slaughtering of animals, etc., which Brutus and Cassius must have held, documented as it is in history and iconography, only a brief visual hint, if anything, could be given.

Dramatic opportunity may even suggest conscious incongruities in minor details. For instance, Brutus was not only a politician but also very much a thinker and reader; at some points he carries with him a book or reads in it. We know, of course, that the Roman book was a scroll (*volumen*); but what with letters and messages of practically the same shape being handled in the play, that book would have been unrecognizable, if it had been a scroll, and therefore ineffective. I suppose I am as responsible as anyone for letting Brutus' book have the appearance of, let us say, a Renaissance small edition of a classic. At least, I confess I refrained from warning anyone about that.

On the other hand, when the question of a common, recognizable emblem for Caesar and his party was raised, and the suggestion was made to use the open hand which appears on top of some of the Roman military standards, that symbol, attractive and recognizable as it might have been, was discarded. It was too special, and had too special a usage on the military *insignia*. The good, fiery, and always serviceable eagle was preferred.

Finally, and most important, there are many situations that